War Dogs Director's Cut (Group 6): Speaker Script

MCCJ 527 | 10-minute group presentation | 6 members × 2 slides × ~50 seconds each

Tips: *Text in [square brackets] is a stage cue, not something to say aloud. Each slide is about 110–130 words, roughly 50 seconds at a calm pace. Practise once with a timer.*

MEMBER 1 – Roll 27 – [Your Name]

Slide 1: Title: War Dogs – A Criminologist's Director's Cut (about 50 seconds)

[Dim the lights if you can. Speak like a movie trailer.] In a world where wars are fought with contracts… two young men from Miami… win almost 300 million dollars to arm an army they will never meet.

[Normal voice.] Good morning. We are Group 6, and today we present War Dogs, the 2016 film. But we are not going to review it like movie critics. We are going to show you a criminologist's director's cut.

We will play the story in three acts: the Hustle, the Deal and the Fall. And at key moments, we will press pause, and explain the organized crime and corruption concepts hiding inside the scene. Our one big question: is this really organized crime?

Slide 2: The trailer: facts and our thesis (about 50 seconds)

First, the trailer facts. War Dogs was directed by Todd Phillips, the director of The Hangover, and released by Warner Bros. in 2016. It stars Jonah Hill as Efraim Diveroli and Miles Teller as David Packouz, with Ana de Armas and Bradley Cooper. It is a comedy, but it is based on a true story, first reported by journalist Guy Lawson in Rolling Stone.

[Right panel.] Here is our thesis: organized crime doesn't always carry guns. Sometimes it sells them, with a government contract. The real company, AEY, won a contract worth 298 million dollars from the Pentagon in 2007.

Let's press play on Act One. [Member 2], roll the film.

MEMBER 2 – Roll 8 – [Your Name]

Slide 3: Act I scenes: the Hustle (about 50 seconds)

Thank you, [Member 1]. Act One: the Hustle. *[Move across the film strip.]*

Scene one: David is a broke massage therapist in Miami. His bedsheet business has failed, and his girlfriend is pregnant. He needs money, fast.

Scene two: he meets his old friend Efraim, whose company AEY bids online for the "crumbs" of military procurement: small contracts the big defence companies ignore. David joins him.

Scene three: a shipment of pistols gets stuck in Jordan, so they fly out, use local fixers and drive it into Iraq. It works, and they get paid.

Scene four: the money flows. New office, new cars. And David starts lying to his partner about what he really does.

[Pause.] Now let's freeze the frame.

Slide 4: Paused: enterprise model and why they did it (about 50 seconds)

[Freeze-frame.] What is happening in Act One?

[Spectrum.] Dwight Smith's enterprise model says legal and illegal business sit on one spectrum, driven by the same market demand. Watch AEY move along it: from legal bidding on crumbs, to grey deals with fixers in Jordan, and later, in Act Three, to outright fraud.

[Bottom cards.] Three theories explain why. Strain theory: David is broke with a baby coming. In Merton's terms he "innovates": he keeps the goal of wealth but uses illegitimate means. Differential association: he learns both the methods and the excuses from Efraim. And rational choice: every step is a calculation, a big reward against a small chance of being caught.

Press play. [Member 3], Act Two.

MEMBER 3 – Roll 37 – [Your Name]

Slide 5: Act II scenes: the Deal (about 50 seconds)

Thank you, [Member 2]. Act Two: the Deal.

Scene five: at an arms fair in Las Vegas, they meet Henry Girard, played by Bradley Cooper. Henry is on a terrorist watch list, so he cannot sell to the US government directly. He needs a front.

Scene six: Henry has access to about 100 million rounds of old rifle ammunition sitting in Albania.

Scene seven: with this cheap supply and a financier behind them, AEY underbids everyone and wins the Afghan army contract, worth around 300 million dollars.

Scene eight: Efraim, greedy as ever, starts planning to cut Henry out of his share.

So let's pause again. Is this group actually organized crime?

Slide 6: Paused: is this organized crime? (about 50 seconds)

[Freeze-frame.] Is AEY organized crime? It depends on the definition.

[Left.] The UN Convention against Transnational Organized Crime says an organized criminal group is three or more persons, structured, existing over time, committing serious crime for material benefit. AEY ticks every box: Efraim, David, their financier, Henry and the suppliers, operating for years, committing fraud and conspiracy for millions.

[Right.] But Abadinsky's classic attributes describe the mafia: hierarchy, exclusive membership, rituals, and an organization that survives when its leaders are arrested. AEY had none of that. It collapsed the moment the founders were charged.

[Bottom.] So our verdict: AEY is organized white-collar crime. A legal company, committing organized and transnational fraud. [Member 4] will show you how the network worked.

MEMBER 4 – Roll 33 – [Your Name]

Slide 7: Paused: the network and who holds power (about 50 seconds)

Thank you, [Member 3]. *[Freeze-frame.]* Who holds the power in this deal? Look at the network. *[Trace the yellow lines.]*

On one side is the US Army, buying through open online tenders. On the other is a stockpile in Albania. They can't connect directly. In the middle sit two brokers: AEY, with a clean American name, and Henry, who has the supply but is on a terrorist watch list.

[Right cards.] This is exactly Morselli's network model: power belongs to the brokers who connect separate worlds. Albini's patron–client model fits too: Henry trades access to supply for a share of the profits.

But Cressey's hierarchical model does not fit at all. There is no boss, no ranks, no family. Next, the corruption that made it all possible.

Slide 8: Paused: corruption formula and state-corporate crime (about 50 seconds)

[Freeze-frame.] Where is the corruption? Transparency International defines corruption as the abuse of entrusted power for private gain. And Robert Klitgaard gives a formula: corruption equals monopoly, plus discretion, minus accountability.

[Cards.] Monopoly: Henry controls the only access to cheap Balkan ammunition, so everyone must pay him. Discretion: officials, fixers and border agents decide with little scrutiny, and middlemen skim money. And low accountability: in wartime urgency, a company run by a man in his early twenties passes the Pentagon's vetting.

[Bottom.] This is state-corporate crime: the harm came from a government policy of outsourcing war to the lowest bidder. And we also see the crime–terror nexus: a watch-listed dealer simply borrows a clean company's name.

[Member 5], Act Three.

MEMBER 5 – Roll 24 – [Your Name]

Slide 9: Act III scenes: the Fall (about 50 seconds)

Thank you, [Member 4]. Act Three: the Fall.

Scene nine: David discovers the ammunition was made in China, which is banned under a US arms embargo, and by the contract itself.

Scene ten: instead of reporting it, they have the rounds repacked to remove the Chinese markings. This really happened.

Scene eleven: David is threatened in Albania, Efraim cheats him out of his money, and their friendship collapses.

Scene twelve: the federal government steps in. In real life, the case was exposed by journalists in 2008. Efraim was sentenced to four years in prison, and David, who cooperated, to seven months of house arrest.

[Pause.] One last freeze-frame. How did they justify all this to themselves?

Slide 10: Paused: techniques of neutralization (about 50 seconds)

[Freeze-frame.] How do two ordinary young men commit fraud on this scale without feeling like criminals? Sykes and Matza call it techniques of neutralization. Offenders know the rules, but use excuses to switch their conscience off.

[Read each yellow line like a subtitle.]

Denial of injury: "The troops still get bullets that work. Who is harmed?"

Condemnation of the condemners: "The government buys from shady sources too."

Denial of responsibility: "We didn't make the bullets, we just moved them."

Appeal to higher loyalties: "I'm doing this for my family."

These are our paraphrases of the characters' attitudes, not exact lines. And notice: every excuse sounds like normal business talk. That is exactly what makes white-collar crime so hard to see.

[Member 6] will give the critics' verdict.

MEMBER 6 – Roll 21 – [Your Name]

Slide 11: The critics' verdict (about 50 seconds)

Thank you, [Member 5]. So what is our critics' verdict? Accurate in substance, exaggerated in style.

[Go row by row.] Conceptual accuracy: four stars. The film fits the UN definition, the enterprise model and the network model very closely.

Factual accuracy: four stars. The contract, the repackaging and the sentences are all true. Henry Girard is a composite character, inspired by a real Swiss broker.

But realism of tone: only two stars. The comedy glamorizes the money and makes fraud look harmless, and the threats in Albania were invented.

And systemic insight: two stars. The film blames two young men, but skips the failure of the system, and real victims, like the 26 people killed in the Gërdec depot explosion in Albania in 2008.

Slide 12: The final cut and credits (about 50 seconds)

So here is our final cut. *[Read slowly.]* Organized crime doesn't always carry guns. Sometimes it sells them, with a government contract.

The answer to our big question: AEY is organized crime under the UN definition, but it is not the mafia. It is organized white-collar crime, best explained by the enterprise and network models.

And a lesson for Bangladesh. Our own large procurement projects also depend on middlemen and intermediaries. Vetting contractors, disclosing who really owns a company, and checking where goods come from are not just paperwork. They are crime prevention.

[Point to the credits.] That's a wrap from Group 6. Thank you, and we're happy to take your questions.